

A night sky with a constellation grid overlay. The grid consists of thin white lines connecting various stars to form constellations. The stars are of different sizes and colors, ranging from small white dots to larger, more prominent stars. The background is a deep blue, suggesting a clear night sky.

*“Why did not somebody teach me the constellations,
and make me at home in the starry heavens,
which are always overhead, and which I don’t
half know to this day?”*

Thomas Carlyle

THE HUMAN EYE HAS ALWAYS seen patterns among the stars. Ancient peoples traced the figures of gods, heroes, and mythical animals onto the skies and used the relationship between these constellations to illustrate myths and legends. In most cases, stars within a constellation lie in the same region of sky merely by chance, however, and are not related. Despite the apparent permanence of the skies, these patterns are not fixed, because all the stars are moving relative to Earth. Over time, the shape of all the constellations will change, and hundreds of thousands of years from now, they will be unrecognizable. Future generations will need to invent constellations of their own. But for now, 88 constellations fill our sky, interlocking like pieces of an immense jigsaw puzzle. Some are large, others small; some richly stocked with objects of note, others faint and seemingly barren. All are featured in the following pages.

PATTERNS IN THE SKY

As darkness falls, a stargazer scans the sky with binoculars. The familiar shape of the Big Dipper looms overhead, part of the constellation Ursa Major, the Great Bear. The north Pole Star, Polaris, can be seen high up on the right.

THE CONSTELLATIONS